THE FALL OF A PATRIARCH

Written by
B. Moore

brian@bmoore-creative.com

INT. WILLIAM'S HOUSE, KITCHEN - NIGHT

JOAN (36) sits in front of her birthday cake as her husband, WILLIAM (40) and their daughter, SALLY (8) finish singing Happy Birthday.

Joan inhales to blow out the "36" candle.

WILLIAM
Wait, did you make a wish?

Joan looks him in the eye with an intense, suggestive gaze.

JOAN
Yes.

She blows out the candle--

William instantly DROPS DEAD to the floor.

SALLY
Daddy!

Sally rushes over to her father, arms out to hold him.

William snaps back to consciousness with a ROAR, lunging at Sally. Grabs her with both arms.

WILLIAM
Gotcha!

He peeks at Joan.

JOAN
(trying not to laugh)
William!

William's phone rings. SAM on the caller ID.

His demeanor shifts as he lets go of Sally.

JOAN (CONT'D)
Who's that?

WILLIAM
Just Ernie. Work stuff.

All eyes on William as he walks off to the other room.

INT. WILLIAM'S HOUSE, BEDROOM CLOSET - NIGHT

POV FROM INSIDE HIS SAFE

Pitch black.

William opens the hatch. Light casts on THREE BANDS of cash and a stack of documents.

He snatches one of the bricks, pulls out a small portion of the bills and puts it in his pocket.

He throws the remaining bundle back in and shuts the door on us.

INT. JAZZ BAR - NIGHT

Intimate, dimly-lit jazz club.

The JAZZ VOCALIST (40) sings of a Paris he's never been to.

Cuddled-up William and Joan enjoy the performance.

His phone vibrates. Joan observes the random number.

He picks up.

WILLIAM
Hello?
(beat)
Jimmy! What happened?
(beat)
Calm down. Where are you?
(looking at his watch)
Alice? I'm with Joan. It's her birthday.
(beat)
Ok Jimmy. I'll be there.

He hangs up.

JOAN
Who's Alice?

WILLIAM
We gotta go.

William stands up. He takes the cash out of his pocket and throws several twenties on the table.

He grabs Joan's arm and tries to pull her up. She refuses.

JOAN
(keeping her voice down)
William, it's my birthday.

WILLIAM
Come on. Don't make a scene.

She gets up.

They walk out.

EXT. WILLIAM'S HOUSE - NIGHT

William's car pulls up to the curb.

INT. WILLIAM'S CAR - CONTINUOUS

Joan steps out. Ready to slam the door on William--

WILLIAM
Wait.

She halts, reluctantly.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
I wouldn't be doing this if it wasn't important.

JOAN
Jimmy? Important?

WILLIAM
He's in trouble.

JOAN
Jimmy's always in trouble.

WILLIAM
It's bad.

She kneels down so she can see William.

JOAN
Just tell me you're not going to bail him out again.

WILLIAM
He doesn't need money. It's not that kind of trouble.

She forces a smile, leans in across the seat and kisses her husband on the cheek.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
I love you.

She locks eyes with him.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
Happy birthday.

MOMENTS LATER

William's car speeds off.

Joan reflects upon the evening as she walks toward the house.

EXT. ALICE RESTAURANT - NIGHT

Establishing the urban, ducked-off entrance.

Red neon signage spells "ALICE."

INT. ALICE RESTAURANT - NIGHT

Throwback little family-owned bistro with repurposed brick walls and sensual lighting.

William sits across a disheveled JIMMY (40). A shot and a beer in front of each.

JIMMY
I need money. To get out of town.

WILLIAM
Just tell me what happened.

JIMMY
It was just like we used to. Ran in there with a sawed-off. The guy bagging up the money pulled a gun. He shot at me.

WILLIAM
So it's self-defense. I can go to Sam and get this straightened out.

JIMMY
Straightened out? He already got a contract on me. I'm marked.

WILLIAM
You don't know that.

Jimmy throws back the whiskey shot.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
How would you know that?

Jimmy slams the glass down.

JIMMY
I know.

Jimmy chugs his beer like it's a competition.

WILLIAM
Take it easy. You're gonna kill yourself.

JIMMY
What's the difference?

WILLIAM
Between living and dying?

Jimmy sinks his head down into his arms.

William shifts in his seat. Jimmy pops his head back up.

JIMMY
Let's go get blowjobs!

WILLIAM
Joan'll smell the strip club on me before I even walk in the house.

JIMMY
You've changed.

WILLIAM
Jimmy, I'm married. It's my wife's birthday. She's waiting up for me.

JIMMY
I could've changed.

WILLIAM
Yeah, well. Who stopped you?

Jimmy reaches across the table and picks up William's shot. Down the hatch.

He stares down at the empty glass.

JIMMY
You're right. Who am I kidding?

WILLIAM
I'm gonna get you a ride. I'll grab five grand for you tomorrow morning. Then, you leave town. And never come back.

JIMMY
Five-thousand?

William takes out his phone. Ready to type.

WILLIAM
I'll make it work. For you. Now, where do you want the Uber to take you?

Jimmy's thoughts race too rapidly to speak.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
Jimmy. The address.

JIMMY
Just have it drop me at the bodega down Elm Street. I'll walk to Cinthia's from there.

William types on his phone.

He takes a moment to think before apparently hitting send.

WILLIAM
Uber will be here in ten.

EXT. ALICE RESTAURANT - NIGHT

Neon "ALICE" sign casts a sinister red glow over William and Jimmy as they walk out.

Green Cadillac with paper tags parked down the curb.

William looks at his phone and points at the Cadillac.

WILLIAM
That's you. The Cadillac.

Jimmy grabs William and hugs him.

JIMMY
Willy. Thank you.

Jimmy walks toward the Cadillac.

He stops dead in his tracks.

JIMMY (CONT'D)
You know you're like a brother to me.

WILLIAM
Jimmy, you already know.

JIMMY
You wouldn't set me up, would you?

WILLIAM
All the shit we done together? If I set you up, I'm the biggest piece of shit to walk the earth.

JIMMY
Promise I'll be okay?

WILLIAM
Jimmy, I promise. You're paranoid.

INT. CADILLAC - NIGHT

Saint Christopher necklace hangs from the rear-view.

Jimmy gets in. DRIVER (40s) locks the doors.

DRIVER
William?

EXT. ALICE RESTAURANT - MOMENTS LATER

William looks at Jimmy through the window as the Cadillac passes by.

He tuns his back as it drives away.

INT. FUNERAL HOUSE - DAY

Jimmy lies dead in the casket.

15-20 people. Some cry. Others console.

Joan scans the old faces in the room, judging the well-dressed, sleazy criminals of her husband's past. Sally sits next to her, on an iPad.

WITH WILLIAM

William walks up to the casket, aiming his eyes at anything except what's in front of him.

Standing above the body, he forces a glance and immediately hurries off, right past his wife and daughter.

BACK OF THE ROOM - CONTINUOUS

SAM (50) delivers a punchline to A FEW GUYS. They laugh.

Something a few yards away grabs Sam's attention---

William approaches THREE GUYS (40's) huddled together clandestinely streaming the Jets/Saints game on a phone.

William looks at the phone just in time to see a touchdown.

WILLIAM
Fucking Saints.

SAM
Willy. Over here.

William pauses before walking over to join Sam.

WILLIAM
Hey Sam.

SAM
What's that you're watching over there?

WILLIAM
(hesitating)
Jets/Saints game.

SAM
That'll fix your problems.

WILLIAM
I can bet with whoever I want now.

SAM
Fucking degenerate.
(lowering his voice)
Your friend over there's not even in the ground yet.

WILLIAM
And my debt's clear.

Sam steps in closer to William, making his authoritative tough-guy persona impossible to ignore.

SAM
Detectives come see you?

WILLIAM
Cops? No.

SAM
What are you gonna say if they do?

WILLIAM
Sam, I would never-

SAM
Shut the fuck up.

Sam steps in again. William reels back and accidentally bumps into a table, making a loud SCREECH.

WITH JOAN AND SALLY

SCREECH!

Joan and Sally look over to see Sam menacing William.

SALLY
Who's that?

Joan places her hand on Sally's knee.

JOAN
One of Daddy's friends. They're just upset about Jimmy.

Joan's eyes covertly glued to her husband.

INT. WILLIAM'S CAR - DAY

The drive home from the funeral. Joan lost in thought.

William agitated at the radio:

RADIO
...In a display of complete domination, the Saints blow out the Jets, sixty-three to twelve.

William reaches for the knob and turns it off.

SALLY
Dad, what happens when you die?

WILLIAM
What?

SALLY
I mean like, when you die. What happens?

William looks to his wife, hoping she'll take this one.

JOAN
William, Sally asked you a question.

He takes a deep breath and addresses Sally in the rear-view.

WILLIAM
Well...
(beat)
One day I'll die. You'll die. Mom'll die... We'll all die. And-

Joan stares at him, scrutinizing his words in real time.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
And I think that uh, the things we do here on earth might have something to do with what happens after we die.

William reflects on what he just said.

Joan smacks him in the arm to snap him out of it.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
Hell doesn't exists. The devil with a pitchfork and fire's just a cautionary tale. You know, to keep people in line. If there's a heaven it's not *some* people go and *some* people don't. It's either everybody or nobody goes to hell.

Joan wasn't aware this cataclysm was even possible.

JOAN
Ignore your father. When you die, you're going to heaven because you're a good girl.

SALLY
No. I just want to know what happens when *you* die, like who gets all your money?

WILLIAM
Sally!

JOAN
Sally!

INT. WILLIAM'S HOUSE, LIVING ROOM - DAY

William makes a drink at the wet bar.

He sits on the couch and turns on Sportscenter. Joan enters.

JOAN
Are you high?

WILLIAM
What?

JOAN
You're the one who pushed to raise her catholic. Now it's *everyone's going to hell?!*

William downs his drink.

WILLIAM
I wasn't ready to answer a question like that.

JOAN
This is our daughter. Do you want her to question her relationship with God for the rest of her life?

William pours another drink.

WILLIAM
I just buried my best friend.

JOAN
<u>Best</u> friend?

William downs the heavy pour.

WILLIAM
He *was* my best friend, until you made me choose *you* over *him*.

JOAN
Look, I understand that Jimmy was you partner in crime-

WILLIAM
You don't understand anything.
Leave me alone.

William sits back down on the couch, fixed on sportscenter.

Joan turns her attention to the TV, then back at her husband.

William pours another drink. She walks off.

INT. WILLIAM'S HOUSE, BEDROOM CLOSET - NIGHT

POV FROM INSIDE WILLIAM'S SAFE

Pitch black.

William opens the hatch. Same three bands of cash.

He grabs two and shuts the door on us.

INT. WILLIAM'S HOUSE, FRONT DOOR - NIGHT

William walks out, cash bricks in hand.

EXT. WILLIAM'S HOUSE, STREET - MOMENTS LATER

Car parked on the curb. William hands the cash to the driver.

INT. WILLIAM'S HOUSE, FRONT DOOR - MOMENTS LATER

William walks in empty-handed.

INT. WILLIAM'S HOUSE, LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

William sits in an armchair, alone in the dark with a glass of rye whiskey. Bottle nearby, almost empty.

Joan takes a couple steps into the room.

JOAN
You gonna come to bed tonight?
(beat)
I know you're going
through...something, but I can't
help you if you don't talk to me.

William ignores Joan and finishes off what's in his glass.

Joan walks away.

WITH JOAN

She processes as she walks down the hallway.

INT. WILLIAM'S HOUSE, BREAKFAST TABLE - MORNING

Joan places a glass of orange juice down in front of Sally.

SALLY
Can we get a puppy?

JOAN
Absolutely not.

William's footsteps approach.

Joan hurries to the microwave and fixes her hair in the reflection.

William enters the room, hungover.

JOAN (CONT'D)
Good morning!

WILLIAM
Morning.

William sits down. Joan sets an OJ in front of him.

JOAN
Toast?

WILLIAM
No.

SALLY
Dad, can we get a puppy?

WILLIAM
Ask your mother.

Sally looks at Joan. She shoots daggers back.

William reaches for his OJ.

He looks up. Eyes a VODKA BOTTLE on the shelf.

The Vodka glares directly back at him clutching his OJ.

An intense stare-down...

DING DONG!

JOAN
I'll get it.

The moment Joan turns the corner, William grabs the vodka and pours it in his OJ.

Sally watches him down the drink as if he's setting a record.

JOAN (O.S.) (CONT'D)
William, will you come here?

INT. WILLIAM'S HOUSE, FOYER - MOMENTS LATER

William's brisk approach stammers as he sees Detectives BRASSER (45) and SCATINO (40) in the doorway with Joan.

JOAN
(attention on William)
This is Detective Brasser and Scatino.

SCATINO
Collin County Homicide. We need you to come down to the station with us and answer some questions.

WILLIAM
Get real.
(beat)
Questions about what?

SCATINO
James Dixon.

WILLIAM
What about him?

SCATINO
When was the last time you saw him?

Joan steps away toward the kitchen.

WITH JOAN

She continues listening as she walks.

WILLIAM (O.S.)
At his funeral.

SCATINO (O.S.)
And when he was alive?

KITCHEN

Joan heads straight for Sally. She kneels down, eye-to-eye with her.

JOAN
Go to your room and I'll bring you a cookie in a few minutes.

SALLY
Okay!!

Sally darts off down the hall. Joan takes a moment to compose herself.

FRONT DOOR

Joan walks to rejoin the trio.

BRASSER (O.S.)
So you're the last person to see him alive?

WILLIAM (O.S.)
No. I told you, he got into an Uber.

BRASSER (O.S.)
An Uber you ordered?

WILLIAM
I didn't order any Uber.

The two detectives exchange a look.

Brasser pulls out a tablet and displays a video. Hits play:

Black and white footage of William looking at his phone while pointing Jimmy to the Cadillac.

Joan notices her husband squirm.

JOAN
I don't know what you're getting at but my husband is a good man.

BRASSER
Sometimes the only difference between a good man and a bad man is his financial stability.

SCATINO
Or lack thereof.

William shifts his eyes from Scatino to Brasser. Both stare into his soul.

JOAN
We're doing just fine.

SCATINO
They kept Jimmy alive for hours. Tortured him.

BRASSER
They won't torture you, though.

WILLIAM
Me?

BRASSER
You're just a loose end. They don't need to make an example out of you. It'll be quick. Clean. Business-like.

SCATINO
Torch the evidence.

WILLIAM
What'd you guys do, rehearse this?

JOAN
Detectives. We're done. If you need anything else, talk to our attorney.

Joan shuts the door on the Detectives.

BINOCULAR POV

The door shuts on Scatino and Brasser. They walk to their car.

INT. WILLIAMS'S HOUSE, LIVING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

William watches the detectives leave through the window.

JOAN
What the hell is going on?

WILLIAM
(hesitating)
Jimmy killed someone when he was trying to rob a card game.

JOAN
Rob a card game?

William nods.

WILLIAM
Turns out the guy had friends.

JOAN
What friends? That guy at the funeral?

WILLIAM
They said if I could set him up, they'd wipe the rest of my debt.

JOAN
Debt?

Joan stands ten feet over her husband.

JOAN (CONT'D)
I've been going out of my way to be uplifting and understanding... and it's fucking gambling again?

WILLIAM
That's all over now.

Joan looks at William with disgust.

Something out the window catches William's eye.

Across the street: The same Cadillac that took Jimmy. The Driver stares directly at him.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
Look.

William moves out of the way. Joan cautiously peers.

JOAN
What am I looking at?

WILLIAM
The green Cadillac.

JOAN
What Cadillac?

William looks out the window: No Cadillac.

He rushes to the door and opens it--

INT. SURVEILLANCE VAN - DAY - CONTINUOUS

Saint Christopher necklace hangs from the rear view.

Driver raises a pair of binoculars up to his eyes.

BINOCULAR POV

William bursts out onto the front porch. He looks both ways down the street, searching for the Cadillac.

He doesn't notice us.

INT. WILLIAM'S HOUSE, FOYER - MOMENTS LATER

William enters and shuts the door behind him.

WILLIAM
It was there. The same car that...
(intense beat)
Get Sally. We gotta go underground.
We're all in danger.

JOAN
We're not going anywhere with you.

WILLIAM
(beat)
Then I'm leaving.

He scurries off down the hall.

JOAN
How much money do we have?

WILLIAM
I don't know.

INT. WILLIAM'S HOUSE, BEDROOM CLOSET - DAY

POV FROM INSIDE HIS SAFE

Pitch black.

William opens the hatch. He grabs the last brick, leaving only the stack of documents.

He shuts the door on us.

EXT. NEIGHBORHOOD SIDEWALK - DAY

Joan and Sally walk hand-in-hand, Sally wearing her book bag.

Something ahead grabs Joan's attention--

Several police cars in front of her house.

Scatino and Brasser on the lawn. They look over and approach.

JOAN
Sally, I need to you go straight inside. I'll be in in a minute.

Sally runs past the detectives and goes inside.

BRASSER
Is your husband home?

JOAN
We separated a last week.

SCATINO
Grand Jury issued his indictment this morning. Conspiracy to commit murder. We have an arrest warrant.

BRASSER
He needs to turn himself in.

Joan looks over at the house. Sally watches from the window.

JOAN
I don't know where he is. You'll have to talk to his lawyer.

INT. JOAN'S HOUSE, BEDROOM CLOSET - DAY

Joan peers under the safe and finds a piece of paper.

She unfolds it, revealing the combination: 15 - 76 - 35.

POV FROM INSIDE THE SAFE

Pitch black.

Joan opens the hatch. She grabs the stack of documents.

INT. JOAN'S HOUSE, FOYER - MOMENTS LATER

Joan walks toward the kitchen as she sorts through the documents: Unpaid bills. Credit card, insurance, mortgage...FINAL NOTICE.

JOAN
Piece of shit.

The front door draws Joan’s eye. A large manilla envelope lies on the floor in front of it.

The mail slot flap still swinging.

Joan freezes in place.

INT. WILLIAM’S MOTEL ROOM - EVENING

Shitty motel. Countless scratch-off lottery tickets strewn about. William scratches his last one with a penny.

Upset, he discards it to the floor and dials on a flip-phone.

INT. JOAN'S HOUSE, KITCHEN - EVENING

Joan plates dinner. Her phone rings.

JOAN
Hello?
(beat)
No, I didn’t cancel your credit card. When you don’t pay the bill, they quit working. And hello to you too.

INTERCUT WITH WILLIAM

WILLIAM
I need help. I gotta switch hotels and I need a credit card.

WITH JOAN

JOAN
What do you need, exactly?
(beat)
Okay. Where are you?
(beat)
I’ll call you. Bye.

She hangs up.

Joan picks up the dinner plates and carries them to Sally. She sits down and eats with her daughter.

INT. CHEVY MALIBU - EVENING

William tosses his suitcase on the seat and sits next to it.

DRIVER (O.S.)
Joan?

William nods. Doors lock. Car moves forward.

He tries to roll the window down. It’s child-locked.

WILLIAM
Could you roll the window down?

DRIVER (O.S.)
It’s broken. I can turn up the A/C.

EXT. INDUSTRIAL AREA - EVENING

The car turns onto a dirt road surrounded by industrial warehouses.

INT. CHEVY MALIBU - CONTINUOUS

William looks out the window. Confused.

EXT. INDUSTRIAL AREA, ALLEY - CONTINUOUS

The car comes to a stop between a couple of warehouses.

INT. CHEVY MALIBU - CONTINUOUS

He looks to the driver in the rear view.

Driver shifts his eyes dead into the mirror.

William makes the dreaded realization.

WILLIAM
No no no. No. NO!

EXT. INDUSTRIAL AREA, ALLEY - CONTINUOUS

PEW! The back windshield instantly turns blood red.

Driver gets out. Walks to the trunk. Opens it. Pulls out a gas can. Opens the driver-side doors. Empties the canister. Lights a match. Tosses it in.

CUT TO BLACK.

POV FROM INSIDE A SAFE

Pitch black.

Sam opens the much bigger hatch. He grabs five of the countless bands of cash.

INT. STRIP CLUB, BACK OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Small room in need of a deep-cleaning.

Sam swivels his chair around to the desk and stuffs the stacks of hundred dollar bills into a large manilla envelope.

He motions for MIKE (50s) to come over.

Sam hands the envelope to Mike.

INT. JOAN'S HOUSE, FOYER - DAY

Joan closes the front door. The envelope in her trembling hand.

She looks over at Sally playing with her toys on the floor.

She walks over and kneels down next to her daughter.

JOAN
Do you want to go look for a puppy?

ROLL CREDITS